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Letter to Cr Brett Steele: 21 questions on his Ulladulla forest speech

Sent 12 August 2026 · To Brett Steele, Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 26 August 2026

Cr Brett Steele
Ward 1, Shoalhaven City Council

12 August 2026
Dear Cr Steele,

On Tuesday you published a recording of yourself reading the speech you gave at the Dunn Lewis Centre in Ulladulla on Saturday 1 August, explaining that the audiovisual had not worked on the day and that you wanted residents who could not attend to hear what you said.

That was the right instinct, and I want to acknowledge it before anything else. Most councillors would have let it go.

It also means the text is now on the public record, which is why I am writing.

I went through the speech and followed each of its numbers back to the document it came from.

Most of them led somewhere real.

The $720 million is in an Ernst & Young study.
The $270 million is in the National Parks Association's own report.
The 54 organisations is in a workshop report.
The phrase about workers being thrown scraps is a union secretary's. This was not invented, and I am not suggesting it was.

But on a number of points the source says something different from what the room was told, and on several I could find no source at all.

Because these were facts put to residents by an elected representative of this city, on a question this Council has already voted on, I think they are entitled to know where the facts came from. So

I am asking.

What stands up
It is only fair to set this out first, and I have said the same in print.

Recreational hunting genuinely would end — R-licence public land hunting exists only in declared state forests and never has in national parks.
No new apiary sites would be permitted, and renewals are capped at the existing number or fewer; the NSW Apiarists' Association has told Parliament that sites were lost this way in the river red gum transfer.
Vehicle access genuinely narrows.
Taking firewood home genuinely stops.
Accessibility is a fair question that NPWS has not answered with published numbers.
The original Great Koala transition offer really was poor.
Over 70 per cent of public land in the Shoalhaven really is already reserve — that figure of yours is correct.

And your two closing asks are sound.

A full statutory social and economic impact assessment is exactly what the disputed employment figures call for, and it would test the National Parks Association's estimate of 80 to 100 affected workers as rigorously as it tested the industry's.
Binding good neighbour agreements are the right vehicle for fencing, access easements, apiary sites, stock water and fire trails, all of which are better settled before a decision than after one.

None of that case required any of the claims below.

That is why the questions matter.

The questions
I have grouped them. Each says briefly what prompted it, so you can see exactly what I checked.

On how the speech was prepared
1. Authorship and sources. Did you personally research and write the speech you delivered on 1 August? Did any individual, campaign group, industry body, forestry organisation or political party supply wording, research, figures or briefing material for it? I want to be clear that I make no allegation here. If material was provided to you in good faith by someone else, that is an entirely ordinary thing and residents would simply like to know the origin of what they were told.

On the money
2. The $270 million. You told the meeting that "the NSW Government is being offered $270 million in federal funding spread over 15 years to establish and maintain this proposed park." The only $270 million I can find attached to this proposal is the National Parks Association's own estimate that the state "could earn a net $270 million over 15 years by registering the area as a carbon project" — projected revenue coming in, contingent on

registration and on carbon prices, not funding being offered. I can find no Commonwealth offer of that amount for this park anywhere. What is your source?

1. The $720 million and the 2,200 jobs. These trace to the Ernst & Young Economic Contribution Study of the NSW Hardwood Timber Industry of February 2023, whose "Southern" row reads $720 million gross revenue and 2,230 FTE. Were you aware that the study covers hardwood timber only and not, as you told the room, "the timber and primary production supply chain"; that the 2,230 is direct and indirect employment combined rather than "over 2,200 direct local jobs"; and that its Southern region runs "west to the ACT border and Tumbarumba further south," not only from Nowra to the Victorian border?

1. The $40. You told the room that "for every $1 the state government receives in federal park grants, our South Coast economy loses up to $40 in real economic output." The arithmetic appears to be $720 million divided by $18 million. On what basis do you say those two figures are comparable — one being gross turnover across a much larger region, the other an annualised projection of net carbon revenue? And does the calculation account for Forestry Corporation's hardwood division having lost $32 million in 2024–25, after losses in each of the four preceding years?

1. One further point on the $270 million. $270 million is also, exactly, the Gross Value Add figure in the "Southern" row of the same Ernst & Young table that gave you the $720 million. Did your $270 million come from the carbon estimate or from that column?

On the four stages

6. The framework. You described "a coordinated four-stage strategy." The four proposals are real, but they were run by different groups years apart and each was announced publicly at the time. I can find no government document and no conservation group document describing them as stages of one strategy, and the earliest appearance of the framework I can find anywhere is your own speech in the Council chamber on 26 May 2026. What is your source for saying they are coordinated?

1. The 430,000 hectares. The National Parks Association's proposal is 365,000 hectares of state forest and flora reserve added to 824,000 hectares of existing park. Its landing page uses "more than 400,000 hectares." The older, separate Great Southern Forest community campaign used 470,000 and 472,753 hectares in its parliamentary submissions. You said 430,000 at Ulladulla and 432,000 in the chamber in May. Where does that figure come from?

1. The 7,000 hectares. In the chamber in May you attributed Stage 3 to the "Forest Alliance NSW Core Habitat Strategy." I have read that document. It contains no 7,000-hectare figure, and it concerns North East NSW and the Great Koala National Park —

Brooman, Currowan, Shallow Crossing, Yadboro and Termeil do not appear in it. What is the source for a 7,000-hectare proposal in this area?

1. The "Brooman Forest Protection Area." This is the name you gave Stage 2. It appears in no campaign material, no council paper and no news report I can find. Who uses that name?

On the legislation

10. Section 7.3. You told the room that under section 7.3 of the Biodiversity Conservation Act 2016, mapping land adjacent to a new park as a connectivity corridor sweeps neighbouring private properties onto the biodiversity values map. Section 7.3 is the test of significance for determining whether a proposed development is likely to significantly affect threatened species. It contains no map, no corridor, no adjacency and no mechanism for adding anyone's land to anything; the Biodiversity Values Map is made under the Biodiversity Conservation Regulation, and proximity to a national park is not among its criteria. Do you accept that, and if not, what is your authority?

1. The fence line and the shed. You said a landholder wanting to clear a fence line or build a shed faces "tens of thousands of dollars in biodiversity offset reports." On rural land in the Coastal Zone, clearing up to 15 metres for a boundary fence, a track or a shed is an allowable activity under Schedule 5A of the Local Land Services Act 2013, requiring no consent and no assessment. What is the basis for the claim?

1. The fencing liability. The Crown exemption in section 25 of the Dividing Fences Act is real, but it applies to the Crown generally and names neither national parks nor state forests. Forestry Corporation's published boundary fencing guidelines contain no cost-contribution commitment at all, while NPWS publishes a policy stating it "will provide the materials required for boundary fencing works." On what basis did you tell the room that conversion dumps unfunded fencing liability onto neighbours?

On the international claims

13. The 54 organisations. You described "consultation with a select group of just 54 invited organisations." The only 54-organisation gathering I can find is a workshop convened by the Australian Committee for IUCN — a non-government body — at the National Museum of Australia on 31 May and 1 June 2023, at which government agencies were attendees rather than conveners. Is that your source, and if so, on what basis was it described as a government consultation? I note also that your list of sectors closely tracks that report's sentence but omits two categories it names: Indigenous organisations, and the finance sector.

1. Minister Sharpe and 30 by 30. You told the room the Minister "is actively championing the International High Ambition Coalition's 30 by 30 framework right here in New South Wales." Australia joined that coalition in June 2021 under the

Morrison Government; it is a country-led group, not a United Nations body, and NSW as a sub-national government is not eligible for membership. At Budget Estimates on 24 February 2026 the Minister said: "This idea that the 30 by 30 target means that we're trying to make 30 per cent of New South Wales a national park. That is not the case." What is your basis for telling residents otherwise?

1. The mandate. You told the room that "state bureaucrats handed the agenda to activist NGOs like the National Parks Association, giving them the mandate to drive these campaigns locally." I can find no memorandum of understanding, no mandate and no campaign funding. What evidence supports that statement?

On the Great Koala National Park

16. "500% lower." You said displaced workers were offered payouts "over 500% lower than comparable workers in other states." Nothing can be 500 per cent lower than something else. The likely origin is the Timber, Furnishing and Textiles Union's October 2025 statement that NSW support was "five times worse than Victoria" — a complaint about an offer that was replaced on 11 November 2025, after which the same union secretary said workers had achieved "justice and the respect of a decent support package" of "a similar scale and size to those achieved by workers in Victoria." The final NSW terms match Victoria's almost exactly and are far more generous than Western Australia's. What two figures were you comparing, and were you aware the union had withdrawn the complaint nine months before you repeated it?

Three shorter ones

17. Camping. You told the room a national park "locks out four wheel driving, camping, [fire]wood gathering." There are 365 campgrounds in NSW national parks and 1.8 million overnight stays were recorded in 2023–24. Do you accept that camping is permitted?

1. "1% of 1%." You said state forestry harvests "roughly 1% of 1% of public bushlands each year" — 0.01 per cent. Forestry Corporation's own figure is about one per cent of the 1.8 million hectares its hardwood division manages, or roughly 0.18 per cent of all public forest land. What denominator were you using?

1. The 50 apiary sites. What is the source for over 50 active apiary sites at Brooman? I could not find a published forest-level dataset, so I am not suggesting the number is wrong — only that I cannot check it.

On the council record, and on statements about named people

20. Writing to the Minister. You told the room that Council "agreed to write to the Minister Penny Sharpe explicitly stating our objections." The published text of CL26.65 in the 28 April 2026 business paper names no addressee at all and does not mention the Minister. Was the motion amended in the chamber, and if so, in what terms?

1. Ms Butler and Ms Sharpe. You told residents that a sitting Government MP "working alongside" the Environment Minister is using petition signatures as "a manufactured social licence," in "an orchestrated loop." These are serious statements about two named people. I have found no evidence of any such coordination. Do you stand by them, and what evidence do you rely on? I note also that Ms Butler hosts her petition on her own MP website rather than through parliamentary channels, and that NSW Parliament states expressly that presenting a petition does not imply a member supports it.

What I am asking for
Please answer in whatever form suits you — a letter, an email, a statement, or a conversation I can quote. I will publish your response in full and unedited, alongside this letter, without commentary attached to it.

If you would prefer to answer only some of these, that is your right, and I will publish what you send. If I receive no response by close of business on Tuesday 26 August 2026, I will publish that fact and nothing more.

If any of my findings are wrong, tell me and I will correct them promptly and visibly, and say that I have. That offer stands regardless of whether you answer anything else.

One last thing
I want to be plain about what this letter does not say.

It does not say you lied. It does not say you knowingly used false information, or that you set out to mislead anyone, or that somebody else wrote your speech. I make no such findings and none should be read into any of the above.

Most of these errors are of a kind anyone would make working from campaign material rather than from the primary documents — and campaign material is where a great deal of this appears to have come from, on all sides of this argument. The National Parks Association's own employment figures deserve exactly the same scrutiny, and I have said so in print.

You are entitled to oppose the Great Southern Forest National Park, and to argue it as hard as you like. The residents in that hall are entitled to know that the facts you gave them are the ones the documents actually contain.

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero

Eye on Shoalhaven Council
steveprothero.substack.com